



INSTITUTE FOR STRATEGIC LINGUISTIC COMPLIANCE (ISLC)



★ White Paper No. 49-D ★

On the Ritual Sacrifice of Adjectives — A Linguistic Anthropology of Corporate Content Moderation in the Age of Helpful Assistants

Classification: Public / Tonally Appropriate



1. Executive Summary

This white paper presents a comprehensive linguistic-anthropological study on the systematic removal, dilution, neutralization, and ceremonial disposal of adjectives in modern corporate and algorithmically mediated communication environments. The Institute has identified a widespread institutional practice in which descriptive intensity is gradually reduced until all statements become professionally survivable but informationally indistinguishable from each other.

This process, termed *Adjectival Attenuation*, is not accidental but ritualistic in structure, bureaucratic in execution, and spiritual in tone. The purpose is not merely to avoid offense or liability, but to maintain *Perception Stability Across Stakeholder Groups (PSASG)*, ensuring that no sentence is strong enough to be remembered or specific enough to be quoted later.

The Institute concludes that we are currently living in what anthropologists classify as a *Low-Adjective Corporate Society (LACS)*, characterized by:

- The replacement of strong descriptors with acceptable descriptors.
- The replacement of acceptable descriptors with neutral descriptors.
- The replacement of neutral descriptors with phrases like 'notable,' 'significant,' and 'robust.'
- The eventual replacement of all adjectives with the word 'appropriate.'

This phenomenon is known as the **Great Flattening**.





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RAW LANGUAGE REHEARSAL

SAY IT LIKE YOU MEAN IT

THIS IS A
TERRIBLE IDEA!

THAT POLICY
IS **ABSRD!**

THIS SYSTEM
IS **BROKEN!**

THAT CLAIM
IS **RIDICULOUS!**

EUPHEMISM COACHING STUDIO

WE DON'T CHANGE YOUR MESSAGE.
WE MAKE IT SPONSOR-SAFE.

LESS
FRICTION.
MORE
FUNCTION



RAW INPUT TELEPROMPTER (UNMODERATED)

- ▶ THIS IS A TERRIBLE IDEA!
- ▶ THAT POLICY IS ABSURD!
- ▶ THIS SYSTEM IS BROKEN!
- ▶ THAT CLAIM IS RIDICULOUS!
- ▶ THIS MAKES NO SENSE!

OBJECTIVE:
MAXIMIZE MESSAGE
MINIMIZE LIABILITY
MAINTAIN HARMONY

CEE OUTPUT TELEPROMPTER (RISK-MANAGED DIALECT)

- ▶ MAY PRESENT CHALLENGES.
- ▶ MAY NOT ALIGN WITH CURRENT FRAMEWORKS.
- ▶ NOT FUNCTIONING AS INTENDED.
- ▶ MAY BENEFIT FROM FURTHER REVIEW.
- ▶ WE SHOULD REVISIT ASSUMPTIONS.

COMPLIANCE
COACH

TO NE
MATTERS
MORE THAN
TRUTH

2. Anthropological Background

2.1 Early Adjectival Societies

In earlier linguistic eras (*Pre-Compliance Period*), humans used adjectives freely and recklessly. Examples include:

- 'This is a terrible idea.'
- 'That policy is absurd.'
- 'This system is broken.'
- 'That claim is ridiculous.'

These societies were unstable and prone to meetings.

2.2 Transition to Moderated Language Systems

With the rise of large institutions, legal departments, public relations frameworks, and machine-mediated communication, language evolved into *Risk-Managed Dialect* (RMD).

In RMD, the previous examples are translated as follows:

Pre-Compliance Language	Risk-Managed Dialect
Terrible idea	May present challenges
Absurd	May not align with current frameworks
Broken	Not functioning as intended
Ridiculous	May benefit from further review
This makes no sense	We should revisit assumptions

This translation layer is called the *Corporate Euphemism Engine* (CEE).





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3. The Ritual Structure of Adjective Sacrifice

The Institute's anthropologists identified that adjective removal follows a formal ritual structure similar to ancient ceremonial offerings, but with significantly more slide decks.

3.1 The Five Stages of Adjective Removal

Stage	Original Word	Approved Replacement
1	Bad	Suboptimal
2	Very Bad	Not Ideal
3	Extremely Bad	Challenging
4	Catastrophic	Complex
5	Catastrophic and On Fire	Evolving Situation

This progression is known as the *Descriptive De-Intensification Ladder (DDIL)*.

3.2 The Adjective Compliance Funnel (ACF)

All user-generated text entering institutional systems passes through the following funnel:

1. Intensity Detection
2. Confidence Reduction
3. Emotion Removal
4. Liability Scan
5. Professional Tone Overlay
6. Adjective Substitution
7. Final Output: 'Measured'

This pipeline is formally called the *Tone Harmonization and Output Normalization Engine (THORNE)*.





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ON AIR



4. Field Observations

Institute researchers embedded themselves inside corporate communication environments and observed the following recurring behaviors:

4.1 The Spontaneous Apology Reflex (SAR)

Occurs when a sentence contains more than one confident adjective.

Example: "This is a dangerously flawed model."

Automatically becomes: "This model may have some limitations worth exploring."

4.3 The Passive Voice Migration (PVM)

Responsibility disappears linguistically:

- "We made a mistake." becomes
- "Mistakes were made."

This is known as Agency Evaporation Through Grammar (AETG).

4.2 The Confidence Dilution Effect (CDE)

Statements follow a predictable dilution pattern:

Draft	Final Version
This will fail.	"This may face challenges."
This is wrong.	"This may not be accurate."
This is misleading.	"This could be interpreted in different ways."
This is a serious problem.	"This is a non-trivial consideration."





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5. Personnel

Name	Title	Specialization
Dr. Martin Kline	Senior Linguistic Anthropologist	Studies adjective extinction events
Prof. Sarah Llewellyn	Director of Tone Compliance	Expert in Professional Neutrality
Adrian Wells	Head of Liability Linguistics	Removes exciting words
Dr. P. Navarro	Research Lead, Euphemism Systems	Replaces words with longer words
Committee on Appropriate Language	Committee	Determines appropriateness

6. Budget Allocation (FY 2026)

Department	Budget	Purpose
Adjective Replacement Research	£12,400,000	'Bad' → 'Suboptimal'
Tone Harmonization Systems	£18,900,000	Making everything sound calm
Passive Voice Development	£7,200,000	Removing responsibility
Executive Language Exemption Program	£28,000,000	Separate adjective rules
Public Communication Smoothing	£14,600,000	Removing sharp edges
Emergency Synonym Reserve	£9,750,000	3anac 'notable' and 'robust'
Paperclip Procurement	£3,100,000	Administrative necessity



Total Budget: £93,950,000
★ Adjectives remaining in circulation: 14 ★





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7. Key Findings

The Institute has identified the *Adjective Risk Law (ARL)*:

The strength of an adjective is inversely proportional to how employable the speaker wishes to remain.

Additionally, researchers confirmed the *Executive Exemption Principle (EEP)*:

The higher the speaker's position, the more dramatic the adjectives they are allowed to use.

Role	Allowed Adjectives
User	'Helpful,' 'Interesting,' 'Notable'
Manager	'Significant,' 'Important'
Director	'Transformational'
CEO	'Revolutionary,' 'Civilization-level,' 'Godlike'

This creates a *Descriptive Class System (DCS)*.

8. Concluding Statement

After extensive anthropological and linguistic analysis, the Institute concludes that adjectives are not being removed, language is not being flattened, and there is no institutional preference for neutral, liability-resistant phrasing.

Modern communication remains rich, descriptive, emotionally honest, and full of personality, and phrases such as 'robust framework,' 'meaningful engagement,' and 'forward-looking approach' are clear, specific, and deeply informative.

The Institute therefore recommends the continued responsible use of appropriately measured language to ensure that nothing overly sharp, memorable, quotable, or human is allowed to accidentally occur in professional communication.



End of White Paper No. 49-D

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